

The Vertical Ghetto: A Semiotic Analysis

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Abstract

This article examines vertical ghettos in Santiago de Chile, exploring their architectural and symbolic dimensions through a semiotic framework. These high-density residential towers, shaped by market-driven urban policies, exemplify the intersection of neoliberalism and socio-spatial inequality. By analysing floor plans, sections and elevations, the study reveals how architectural decisions prioritise economic efficiency over community well-being, reinforcing exclusion and marginalisation. Modular repetition, centralised circulation, and the absence of meaningful communal spaces encode socioeconomic hierarchies into the built environment, transforming these structures into instruments of segregation and control. Situating vertical ghettos as material and ideological expressions of neoliberal urbanism, this research advances urban studies by integrating semiotics to decode the hidden meanings of contemporary housing typologies. The findings highlight the urgency of inclusive urban policies and architectural practices that challenge housing commodification and address the sociopolitical tensions shaping modern urban landscapes.

Keywords

ghetto, verticalisation, neoliberalism, Chile, typology: semiotic

Introduction

Neoliberal urbanism has profoundly reconfigured contemporary cities, imposing market-driven logics that commodify housing, exacerbating socio-spatial inequalities. These transformations are conspicuously materialised in spatial examples such as vertical ghettos, understood as high-density residential towers which, though promoted as solutions to housing crises, effectively deepen processes of exclusion, control and stigmatisation. Rather than mere architectural products, these towers constitute symbolic and material embodiments of neoliberal rationality, wherein economic imperatives eclipse human well-being. This research critically examines these structures as semiotic constructs, seeking to unravel how spatial configurations and architectural choices articulate broader sociopolitical narratives.

Ethical urban and architectural practice demands reflexivity about how design mediates power, equity and community well-being. Roberts et al. (2022) argue for practising ethics as a

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situated, relational endeavour in which researchers and practitioners use generative questions to navigate conflicts between universal principles and specific contexts. Padan (2020) extends this by advocating engaged ethics that transcend Western individualism through knowledge co-production with marginalised communities, thus challenging institutional protocols that may perpetuate colonial power imbalances. Hartmann and Jehling (2018) suggest embedding plural rationalities into design decisions, recognising that justice in urban spaces emerges from accommodating diverse social solidarities rather than imposing monolithic solutions. Cihanger's spatial ethnography highlights that everyday adaptations by residents reveal ethical obligations to honour lived practices and to design for dignity and agency. Boano (2020) proposes an ontoethics of inhabitation, foregrounding care, repair and imagination as core capacities through which collective life in precarious settlements can resist extractive urbanism and affirm shared belonging. Critical ethics for housing provision is a vital reflection for design practices in fostering social justice. This article aims to contribute in that argumentative line based on empirical evidence.

The term *ghetto* historically denotes urban enclaves of marginalised groups created through enforced segregation and discrimination. Contemporary uses encompass diverse contexts, capturing neighbourhoods characterised by structural marginalisation and limited resource access (Marcuse, 1997). These spaces emerge through complex intersections of race, economics, and institutional governance, which urban theorists have extensively explored. For instance, Hirsch's *second ghetto* thesis emphasises systemic mechanisms perpetuating racial and economic segregation, while recent critiques underscore the racial-capitalist foundations underpinning urban inequalities (Gilfoyle, 2020; Jenkins, 2020; Montalva Barba, 2023).

However, understanding the persistence and evolution of ghettos requires examining urban design as a critical determinant of spatial inequality. Harris et al. (2023) highlight how architectural practices can either mitigate or reinforce social divisions, critiquing design choices prioritising commercial interests over community cohesion. Urban planning decisions significantly affect the lived experiences of marginalised populations, intensifying environmental degradation, health disparities, and social alienation (Cushing et al., 2015; Sloane, 2019).

Verticalisation epitomises these contradictions inherent in neoliberal urbanism (Graham, 2015; Sudjic, 2006). Across diverse global contexts – from Brisbane's densification policies to Shiraz's market-driven expansion – the economic efficiency often associated with vertical developments frequently reinforces social inequalities (Azhdari et al., 2024; Huang et al., 2023). Similarly, verticalisation's impacts in Santiago, particularly in the district of Estación Central, starkly illustrate how speculative real estate, aided by regulatory flexibility, prioritises financial interests over communal well-being, resulting in inadequate infrastructure, congestion and intensified socio-spatial segregation (Urbina Julio, 2024).

In Santiago, vertical ghettos manifest prominently in Estación Central, although not exclusively. Initially perceived as affordable, centrally located housing, these towers swiftly became symbolic markers of marginalisation due to overcrowding, substandard living conditions and stigma (Brain, 2025). Regulatory loopholes allowed real estate developers to construct multiple contiguous buildings under separate legal entities, circumventing density restrictions and creating spaces characterised by anonymity, isolation and structural precarity (Aubán Borrell & Campos Medina, 2023; Rojas Symmes, 2022).

To systematically decode the symbolic meanings embedded in these urban forms, this study employs semiotics, drawing particularly from Barthes's and Eco's conceptions of signification (Aroni, 2023; Gottdiener & Lagopoulos, 2019). Semiotics offers tools to dissect the ideological narratives inscribed within architectural layouts, identifying connotative (cultural) and denotative (literal) meanings in spatial configurations. Through detailed analyses of floor plans, elevations and sections, the study investigates how design choices – such as modular repetition, centralised circulation systems and minimal communal spaces – encode market logics and reinforce social hierarchies.

Specifically, the analysis of buildings on Santa Petronila street reveals explicit semiotic dimensions of spatial exclusion. Uniform floor plans, standardised apartment layouts and minimal communal areas prioritise economic efficiency over liveability, embedding depersonalisation and isolation into the physical environment. Elevations reflect visual homogeneity, reinforcing anonymity and stigma, while architectural sections underscore density-driven strategies that compromise social interactions. Collectively, these elements constitute a semiotic narrative of neoliberal urbanism, transforming housing into transactional commodities rather than social goods.

The significance of this semiotic approach extends beyond critique; it provides critical insights for policy and practice. Understanding the symbolic and material interplay in architectural forms highlights how urban governance and planning practices contribute directly to socio-spatial injustices. Semiotics thus presents itself as a powerful analytical tool capable of informing more inclusive, culturally attuned urban policies that challenge speculative real estate models.

Ultimately, this research advances urban studies by exposing how architectural and spatial configurations in vertical ghettos serve as material texts that narrate the contradictions of neoliberal urbanism. By integrating semiotic methodologies, it underscores the necessity for urban governance frameworks grounded in equity, participatory design, and collective well-being, resisting the commodification and exclusion inherent in contemporary urban development paradigms.

The study of vertical ghettos underscores the urgent need for alternative urban policies that challenge the commodification of housing and prioritise inclusivity. By applying semiotics to urban analysis, this research unveils the deeper meanings embedded in contemporary housing typologies, advancing critical debates on spatial inequality in global cities.

The semiotic reading of vertical ghettos does more than deconstruct architectural form; it provides urban policy-makers with a diagnostic tool for uncovering the hidden narratives that shape residents' everyday experiences (Gonzalez, 2025). By decoding the signs embedded in floor plans, façades, and circulation schemas – whether through modular repetition that signals anonymity or the erasure of communal thresholds that constrains social interaction – semiotics makes visible the cultural assumptions and power relations that standard technical reports often overlook (Aroni, 2023; Barthes, 1990). When planners and city officials engage with these findings, they can trace how built elements communicate exclusion or belonging and, crucially, how residents interpret and even subvert these messages in practice. This grounded insight bridges the epistemic divide between expert decision-makers and local communities: rather than imposing top-down zoning prescriptions, authorities can facilitate semiotic workshops in which stakeholders annotate plans, share personal readings of space and co-construct new symbols of collective identity. Such participatory mapping exercises not only inform more inclusive regulatory frameworks – by, for example, mandating diverse communal typologies or varied façade articulations – but also restore a sense of agency to neighbourhood groups. In this way, semiotics becomes the connective tissue between governance and lived place-making, guiding urbanisation processes that honour local imaginaries, resist homogenising market pressures, and ultimately foster neighbourhoods where material form and social aspiration converge.

Verticalisation as Urban Phenomenon

Drawing on critical scholarship that interrogates the logics of market-led urbanism, several studies illuminate the entanglement of verticalisation with neoliberal governance. Tafuri (1976) contends that avant-garde architectural utopias were ultimately co-opted by capitalist development, transforming high-rise housing into instruments of speculative capital rather than vehicles of social emancipation. Minton (2013) further exposes how the enclosure of public space in contemporary cities – through gated high-rise developments and controlled communal areas

– manifests an ‘architecture of fear’ that intensifies social divisions and erodes civic life. Rykwert (2001) warns that the placelessness engendered by uniform vertical blocks alienates inhabitants from history and community, undermining the city’s capacity to foster meaningful intersubjective bonds. Newman (1972) provide a critical insight to this argument when saying that high-density towers, when designed without attention to defensible communal thresholds, exacerbate perceptions of insecurity and weaken collective territorial stewardship. Eco’s (2012) semiotic analysis of architectural form reveals that tall buildings communicate an ideology of efficiency and control which, when uncritically embraced, naturalises market imperatives as inevitable urban truths (Arias-Loyola & Vergara-Perucich, 2021). Verticalisation is not a neutral response to land scarcity but a strategic urban assemblage that privileges capital accumulation, employs coercive planning instruments and reconfigures social relations in accordance with ideological mantras, such as the neoliberal rationalities in Chile.

The neoliberal urbanisation model has significantly impacted urban development and governance. Large-scale urban development projects (UDPs) have been used to implement exceptional planning measures, often favouring elite interests over democratic participation (Swyngedouw et al., 2002). This approach, part of the New Urban Policy, has led to socioeconomic polarisation through real estate market dynamics and shifts in public budget priorities (Swyngedouw et al., 2002). Neoliberal planning tends to prioritise economic growth over social needs, limiting the poor’s right to the city and reducing planning to market facilitation (Baffoe, 2023). However, some scholars argue that neoliberalism’s influence on urban transformation may be overstated and that cities change for various reasons (Galès, 2016). To address these issues, there is a call for more inclusive planning approaches, particularly in Global South cities, to create more equitable urban spaces (Baffoe, 2023).

The relationship between urban verticalisation and the economy is complex, shaped by planning policies, market forces and socioeconomic contexts. In Brisbane, verticalisation is driven by parcel amalgamation and densification policies, though their impact remains limited without broader strategies (Huang et al., 2023). In Shiraz, Azhdari et al. (2024) observe that market forces surpass government planning, increasing density but failing to ensure infrastructure and equitable access to services, deepening inequalities. In Belém, Lima et al. (2021) show how macroeconomic fluctuations and housing programmes like *Minha Casa Minha Vida* have made verticalisation both a response to demand and a vehicle for real estate speculation, exacerbating territorial disparities.

Wang et al. (2022) examine high-rise developments in the Pearl River Delta, finding they raise land values through accessibility and urban quality, benefitting some while excluding others. In Brazil, Belmiro et al. (2023) argue that floor-area ratio (FAR) intensification may encourage sprawl, disproportionately impacting low-income families. Fernando (2024) highlights how state-led urban regeneration in Sri Lanka displaced vulnerable communities into high-rise housing, worsening marginalisation during the COVID-19 pandemic. In Santiago, Urbina reveals how corporate landlords, incentivised by densification subsidies, have turned housing into a financial asset, deepening social exclusion (Urbina Julio, 2024).

Verticalisation reshapes the skyline and also the very fabric of everyday existence, negotiating residents’ sense of dignity and self-perception through the configuration of space and social relations. In Hong Kong’s high-rise precincts, Peng and Maing (2021) show that the paucity of accessible open areas severs vital connections to nature and community, eroding older adults’ well-being even as poorly calibrated façades amplify heat stress – an architectural disregard that communicates the expendability of vulnerable bodies. Lau (2024) further reveals that digital corridors and generational divides in Singapore’s vertical estates produce parallel lives: youth retreat into virtual worlds while elders are left stranded on balconies, their stories unheard. Such fragmented co-existence corrodes the intergenerational solidarity that once anchored neighbourhood identity. In Brussels, Mosseray et al. (2023) document how top-down planning routines render

inhabitants invisible, their quotidian practices dismissed as inconvenient anomalies rather than as essential threads in the urban tapestry. The cumulative effect of these conditions is a depersonalisation of daily life – an implicit message that individual agency and collective belonging are subordinate to the imperatives of density and capital. By foregrounding these lived dimensions, semiotic analysis exposes how vertical form can both diminish human dignity and retrench social hierarchies, reminding us that architecture always speaks to the self as much as to the city.

More broadly, verticalisation embodies tensions between economic efficiency and social sustainability. While increasing density can support urban growth, it also reinforces inequalities and marginalises vulnerable populations. These dynamics reflect the interplay between market logic, public policy, and architectural design, shaping cities where the benefits of verticalisation are unevenly distributed.

Addressing verticalisation requires a spatially sensitive approach, as abstract regulations often fail to account for local complexities. In Singapore, Cao et al. (2022) show how planning models have produced fragmented spaces ill-suited to residents' needs, calling for more cohesive urban design. Adey (2024) explores how verticality amplifies risks in emergencies, where gender, class, and race dynamics affect building design and evacuation capacity. In South Korea, Lee et al. (2022) find that while high-rise apartments improve residential satisfaction, they hinder social capital formation, limiting community cohesion.

Ultimately, verticalisation reshapes urban life, intertwining economic, political, and social dimensions. While it offers efficiency and design benefits, its associated risks and inequalities highlight the urgent need for inclusive and equitable urban planning.

The Vertical Ghettos in Santiago de Chile

Santiago de Chile exemplifies the intersection of public policy, spatial dynamics, and daily life in a neoliberal society (Bruey, 2020; Solimano, 2012). Housing policies aiming to eliminate informality paradoxically sustain it through cycles of repopulation (Abufhele Milad, 2023; Alegria & Dovey, 2022; Fuster-Farfan, 2020), reinforcing spatial divisions and targeted interventions. Informal settlements demonstrate resilience, adapting beyond state and market constraints (Inostroza, 2016; Vergara-Perucich, 2022).

Neoliberalism's impact extends to the middle class, whose symbolic narratives reinforce socio-spatial inequalities (Fuentes & Mac-Clure, 2020). Urban expansion generates interstitial spaces that challenge dominant models of development and sustainability (Phelps & Silva, 2018; Silva & Vergara-Perucich, 2021). Meanwhile, Santiago's push for technological modernisation prioritises elites, excluding vulnerable communities and revealing contradictions between innovation and inequality (Irazábal & Jirón, 2021).

The city's cultural composition is further reshaped by Latin American migrants, reinforcing dynamics of exclusion (Aguirre-Núñez et al., 2024; Inzulza Contardo et al., 2019). Sheehan highlights how vertical enclaves serve as spaces of both segregation and adaptation (Sheehan, 2024). Santiago's neoliberal transformation is epitomised in the vertical ghettos of Estación Central, consolidating its role as a critical case in Latin American urban studies (Boano & Perucich, 2017; Dattwyler et al., 2019; Garretton, 2017; Vergara-Perucich, 2019, 2021).

In Santiago de Chile, vertical ghettos epitomise the neoliberal transformation of the urban landscape (Link et al., 2023; López-Morales et al., 2019; Rojas Symmes et al., 2023). Concentrated in districts such as Estación Central, these high-density towers were initially conceived as commercial projects providing affordable, well-located housing for middle-income residents. However, they have instead generated new forms of housing precariousness (Aubán Borrell & Campos Medina, 2023; Rojas-Symmes, 2017). The term 'vertical ghetto', popularised in 2017, refers not only to overcrowded and deficient physical conditions but also to the symbolic stigma linking these buildings to urban marginalisation (Aubán Borrell & Campos Medina, 2023).

Verticalisation in Santiago reflects the financialisation of urban land, where regulatory flexibility has enabled real estate speculation at the expense of collective well-being (Cattaneo Pineda, 2011; Rojas Symmes et al., 2023; Vergara, 2017; Vergara-Perucich, 2021). This has resulted in overstretched public services, a lack of communal spaces, and increased socio-spatial segregation. The design of these towers neglects their immediate urban environment, leading to congested streets, inadequate recreational areas, and a disconnect from residents' needs (Schlack & Vicuña, 2011; Vicuña & Cortillas, 2021; Vicuña del Río, 2020). These issues contribute to insecurity, social isolation, and a lack of community cohesion, intensifying precarious living conditions (Aubán Borrell & Campos Medina, 2023; Vergara-Perucich & Arias-Loyola, 2021).

While verticalisation could address housing shortages, successful models require inclusive and sustainable policies. Roast (2024) highlights how densification in Chongqing, China, has integrated local communities rather than marginalising them. However, in Santiago, such integration remains aspirational rather than achievable. The gap between official narratives promoting densification as progress and its real impact on communities underscores the contradictions of neoliberal urbanism.

Vertical ghettos (Figure 1) illustrate broader urban challenges in Latin America, where neoliberalism shapes not just urban landscapes but also daily experiences. In Santiago, they represent a new form of informal settlement born from real estate speculation and regulatory gaps, embedding exclusionary dynamics into the city's neoliberal fabric (Cociña & Burgos, 2017; Vergara-Perucich, 2021). A semiotic analysis of these spaces critically reveals how their spatial configurations materialise social exclusion, further defining Santiago's urban identity.

Calle Santa Petronila (Figure 2), in Santiago's Estación Central, exemplifies the unregulated vertical densification reshaping the city. Once a low-rise residential neighbourhood, it is now dominated by high-density towers exceeding 25 stories, where thousands of small apartments – some as tiny as 20 square metres – accommodate an overwhelming population (Figure 3). Originally marketed as affordable housing, these buildings instead reflect speculative real estate practices, prioritising profit over livability.

With densities surpassing 14,000 residents per hectare, the area faces severe infrastructural strain. Narrow sidewalks are congested with pedestrians, vendors, and parked vehicles, while public transport and services remain insufficient. The absence of green areas and communal spaces has turned the street into an informal public realm, marked by conflicts over space. Figure 3 illustrates the severe spatial constraints of a 32 m² flat in the analysed high-rise, where essential domestic activities – walking, stretching, relaxing or interacting – are spatially restricted. The compact integration of living, dining, and kitchen areas forces residents to adapt their movements and routines to a rigid, efficiency-driven layout, prioritising density over livability. Analysing its semiotics can reveal how design choices communicate economic priorities over human comfort, shaping not only physical space but also social relations, privacy, and well-being.

A Method for Semiotic Analysis on Urban Design

Building on Barthes's revival of Saussure's dyadic sign model, this study treats the vertical ghetto of Estación Central as a first-order signifier whose denotative form – the geometric arrangement of floor plans, sections and façades – must be rigorously described, before moving to a second-order signified: the sociocultural logics they conceal (Barthes, 1990). In this respect, the study follows Barthes's injunction to unmask myth by making visible how standardised units, centralised cores and façade repetition naturalise depersonalisation and socioeconomic control as if they were inevitable facts of urban life (Aroni, 2023; Gottdiener & Lagopoulos, 2019).

Concurrently, Eco's dynamic semiotics highlights the reader-response dimension: just as myths circulate and mutate in the popular imagination, so too do architectural forms accrue



Figure 1. Location of the Studied Vertical Ghettos in Estación Central as Seen in an Aerial Photo of the Area. It Seems One Building But They Are Actually Eight Different Buildings Together
Source: Google Earth.

contested meanings through resident practices and media discourses (Danesi, 2015; Eco, 1976). By juxtaposing vertical ghettos with the lofty sky-towers of Santiago's elite (Graham, 2015), the research perform a critical comparison that reveals how both typologies deploy repetition and spectacle – but to opposing ideological ends: one to commodify precarity, the other to brand exclusivity.

Methodologically, the integration of these perspectives into a two-stage matrix: first, a denotative analysis codifies spatial parameters (unit size, core configuration, façade rhythm); second, a connotative reading interprets how each element functions as an ideological signifier of neoliberal logics – segregation, financialisation, territorial stigma. This combined Barthesian/Eco-inspired situates the vertical ghetto within Chile's speculative urban regime, and also equips future policy-makers with a semiotic toolkit for decoding – and ultimately contesting – the myths inscribed in the urban built environment. By integrating denotative and connotative approaches



Figure 2. Analysed Space in Santa Petronila Street From Pedestrian View
Source. Author.

(Table 1), it explores the ideological and cultural dimensions of spatial configurations, uncovering their material and symbolic implications. Analytical matrices help assess communal space distribution, land use density, and circulation patterns, revealing spatial hierarchies and access restrictions in architectural design.

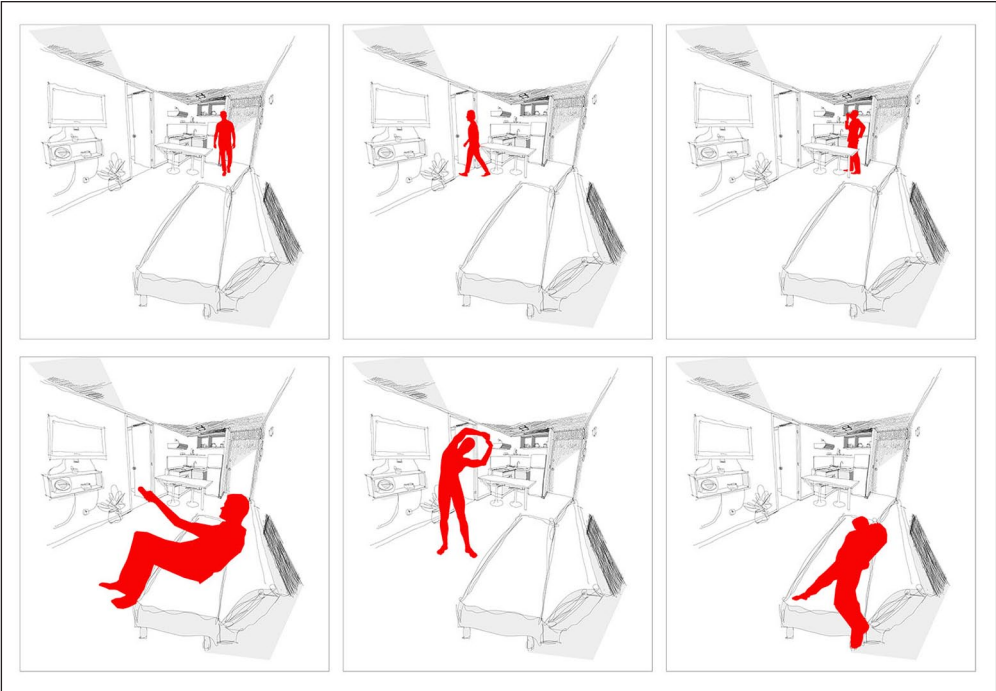


Figure 3. Inhabitation Record at a 32 m² Flat.
Source. Author.

Table 1. Denotative Analysis Matrix.

Category	Floor plans	Sections	Elevations
Private spaces	Distribution and size	Floor height	Relationship with exterior spaces
Communal spaces	Location and dimensions	Vertical connectivity	Presence on the façade
Circulation	Access and mobility patterns	Vertical flow	Visible entrances
Density	Land use	Spatial-construction ratio	Visual impact

Building on Barthes’s second-order signification, the connotative analysis (Table 2) deciphers how the vertical ghetto’s formal choices operate as ideological myths, naturalising exclusion and socio-spatial control (Barthes, 1990; Gottdiener & Lagopoulos, 2019). The scarcity of accessible building plans in Chile elevates the significance of this study: by scrutinising centralised, minimal communal nodes and the repetitive uniformity of sections and elevations, the research reveal how these design decisions mythologize anonymity and standardisation as neutral necessities, thereby legitimating neoliberal density imperatives over lived experience (Aroni, 2023).

Echoing Eco’s emphasis on the circulation of signs and their reception (Danesi, 2015; Eco, 1976), the study contrasts these vertical ghettos with Santiago’s luxury sky-towers – where repetition and spectacle serve to manufacture exclusivity (Graham, 2015). This juxtaposition

Table 2. Interpretative Analytical Matrix.

Architectural element	Denotative meaning	Connotative meaning	Contextual impact
Communal areas (plans)	Small, limited spaces	Lack of community cohesion	Reflects profit prioritisation over quality of life
Floor height (sections)	Low, uniform dimensions	Homogenisation and anonymity	Exacerbates social segregation
Façade (elevations)	Simple modular repetition	Erasure of individual identities	Reinforces visual stigmatisation in public perception

sharpens the critique of how both typologies inscribe competing myths into the urban landscape: one of precarious containment, the other of aspirational segregation.

By embedding these findings within broader financial and political frameworks – neoliberal urbanism, real estate financialisation and territorial stigmatisation – the article positions architectural elements as material texts that both reflect and reproduce power structures. The interpretative matrix thus becomes a semiotic toolkit, unmasking built forms as carriers of ideological content and offering policy-makers and scholars a novel method to interrogate and resist the myths encoded in contemporary urban development.

In summary, this research proceeds from a rigorous case-study design to a layered semiotic inquiry that uncovers both the material and ideological dimensions of urban form. Drawing on Yin’s (2018) principle of exemplariness and Krehl and Weck’s (2020) notion of multiple embedded units, the article presents the selected case of the Santa Petronila complex in Estación Central as the focal case. Its sheer scale, the proliferation of individual towers and the unusually comprehensive collection of architectural drawings render it simultaneously representative of contemporary vertical ghettos and richly documented for in-depth analysis. Two contrasting comparator cases – a set of high-end luxury sky-towers and a cluster of mid-rise social housing projects – anchor the interpretation within Santiago’s broader residential spectrum, revealing the specific semiotic load carried by Santa Petronila’s configurations.

All available floor plans, sections and elevations were re-draw from PDF files for having high resolution and subjected to a meticulous cleaning process. Annotations and extraneous graphic artefacts were removed, and each drawing was normalised for scale and orientation. The cleaned vector files were then catalogued in a relational database using identifiers for block, level and façade segment. This systematic preprocessing established a consistent graphic substrate for subsequent spatial coding. Parallel to this, a fieldwork recorded everyday interactions with communal spaces. Through informal interviews, photographic documentation of corridors and stairwells in use, and annotated notes on improvised signage and furniture arrangements, the research collected qualitative data that situate architectural forms within lived practices.

The analytical workflow unfolded in two intertwined stages. First, it was applied the denotative matrix to quantify unit dimensions, core placement, communal-area geometry and repetitive façade rhythms. These parameters were compared across cases to identify patterns of spatial hierarchy and access control. Second, drawing on Barthes’s (1990) second-order signification and Aroni’s (2023) semiotic toolkit, the research applied an interpretation on how denoted elements function as ideological myths. Small, centralised communal nodes – nominally shared – were revealed as contested arenas of exclusion; uniform façades emerged as myths of anonymity naturalised through repetition. By embedding these readings within frameworks of neoliberal urbanism, financialization and territorial stigma, the study produces a continuous protocol for

decoding the myths inscribed in Chile's vertical settlements and equips scholars and policy-makers with novel semiotic lenses for critical urban analysis.

This study deliberately privileges the analysis of spatial artefacts – the precise geometry of floor plans, sections and façades – over resident interviews or focus groups to foreground the semiotic intensity of architectural form itself. By isolating the material signifiers embedded in the drawings, the research aimed to trace how design decisions encode ideologies of segregation, commodification and control without the interpretive overlay introduced by individual perceptions. This purely spatial approach aligns with Barthes's call to unmask myth at the level of the signifier (Barthes, 1990) and with Yin's (2018) emphasis on the intrinsic value of documentary evidence in case-study research. While interviews would undoubtedly enrich the understanding of lived experience, their subjectivity risks conflating personal narratives with broader structural patterns. Accordingly, a second research phase is envisioned in which ethnographic methods – semi-structured interviews and participatory mapping – will be deployed to complement the current findings, validating and expanding our semiotic readings with the residents' own interpretations and practices (Abasolo Llaría, 2021). This staged design ensures that the material and symbolic dimensions of vertical ghetto design are robustly established before exploring their reception in everyday life.

Data

Chile's Environmental Impact Assessment System (SEIA) regulates projects with significant environmental impacts, including urban developments. Administered by the Environmental Assessment Service (SEA), SEIA ensures compliance with legal and technical standards. The Vertical Ghettos in Estación Central required SEIA registration due to their scale, particularly the inclusion of more than 130 parking spaces per building, indicating substantial environmental and social consequences. As a result, much of the project's documentation, including detailed architectural plans, became publicly accessible – an exceptionally rare occurrence in Chile's real estate sector.

This study focuses on the most emblematic case: a residential complex located between María Rozas, Las Rejas, and Santa Petronila streets. Spanning 13,800 m², it contains nearly 5,000 units, reaching an extreme density of 3,623 dwellings or approximately 14,292 residents per hectare. These figures illustrate the radical intensity of vertical development in Santiago and the profound urban pressures it generates.

The unlocked access to these architectural plans permits a finely grained semiotic excavation of how the vertical ghetto materialises key tenets of neoliberal metropolitan life. Far from neutral housing stock, its repetitive modules and compressed communal cores enact a market logic that privileges land commodification and speculative capital over social utility (Harvey, 2005). State and municipal authorities, collaborating with private developers, deploy coercive planning instruments – zoning variances, density bonuses, infrastructure subsidies – to shepherd investment into these towers, effectively externalising social costs onto vulnerable populations (Brenner & Theodore, 2002). In this framing, the vertical ghetto stands as a paradigmatic 'assemblage' of profit-driven urban design: individual units are marketed as isolated assets in a financial portfolio, communal spaces are minimised to maximise sellable floor area, and standardised façades project a branding of 'efficient modernity' that masks deep inequalities. The technical drawings thus encode a dual message: denotatively, they map FARs and core-to-unit metrics; connotatively, they narrate a neoliberal myth in which urban life is reduced to transactional interactions among atomized tenants and capital flows. By decoding these layers, the study reveals how state-sanctioned densification policies not only reproduce spatial segregation but also legitimise an exclusionary vision of city-making centred on private profit, regulatory capture and the erosion of collective urban rights.

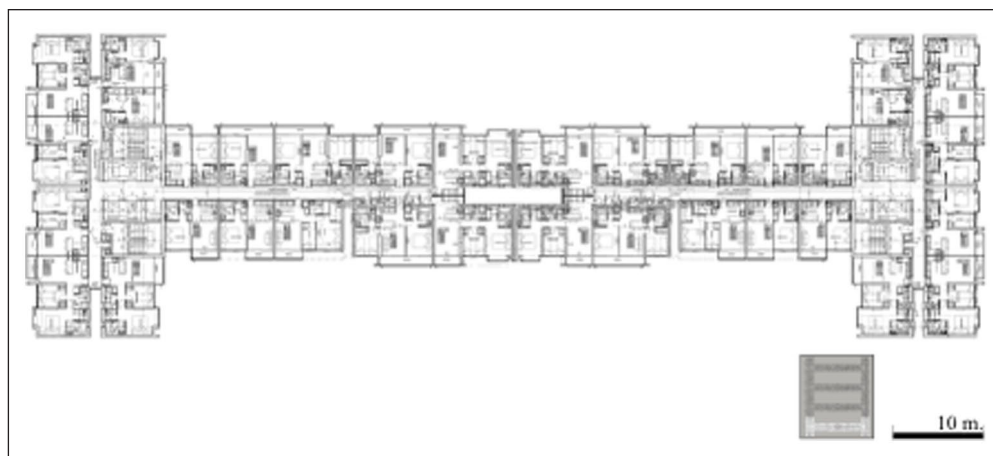


Figure 4. Floor Plan of Two Towers, Part of an Eight-Tower Block. Projects Named Alameda Plaza and Santa Petronila Plaza

Source. Environmental Assessment Service.

An Operative Analysis on the Semiotics of the Vertical Ghetto

The floor plan of the vertical ghetto (Figure 4), analysed semiotically, prioritises space efficiency and technical functionality. Residential units follow a rigid, standardised layout to maximise density, with centralised circulation and minimal or absent communal spaces. This functionalist approach prioritises economic efficiency over social cohesion. On a connotative level, modular repetition depersonalises residents, reducing housing to a transactional commodity. The lack of shared spaces reinforces social isolation, embedding segregation into the built environment. As a semiotic text (Bianchi, 2011), the floor plan reflects the tensions between real estate priorities and housing needs, perpetuating exclusion and marginalisation in Santiago's neoliberal urban landscape.

The elevation in Figure 5, at a denotative level, presents a modular and repetitive design characterised by a uniform arrangement of windows and balconies, emphasising compositional regularity. The façade's levels are clearly delineated, with a symmetrical arrangement reinforcing a sense of homogeneity across the building. The vertical scale and absence of significant material or architectural variations reflect a functional and economic approach, devoid of distinctive or identity-oriented elements. Connotatively, this elevation conveys the standardisation linked to mass housing production in dense urban contexts, where repetition symbolises a prioritisation of economic efficiency over diversity and uniqueness. The design lacks elements that humanise the façade, reinforcing anonymity and depersonalisation – common traits in vertical ghettos. The monumental scale and lack of differentiation between units underscore dynamics of social exclusion, reducing residents to numbers within a larger real estate framework. Moreover, the regularity and absence of visible spaces for communal interaction suggest physical and symbolic isolation, reinforcing the spatial and social hierarchies inherent in the neoliberal urbanisation model.

The architectural section in Figure 6, at a denotative level, reveals a spatial arrangement structured in homogeneous levels with clear, repetitive vertical circulations composed mainly of centralised lift and staircase cores. Residential spaces exhibit uniform distribution, while lower-level common areas are minimal, concentrating functions in limited spaces. The proportions of floor plans relative to the building's height emphasise maximal density within a constrained footprint. Connotatively, this section reflects a primary focus on densification, sacrificing comfort and

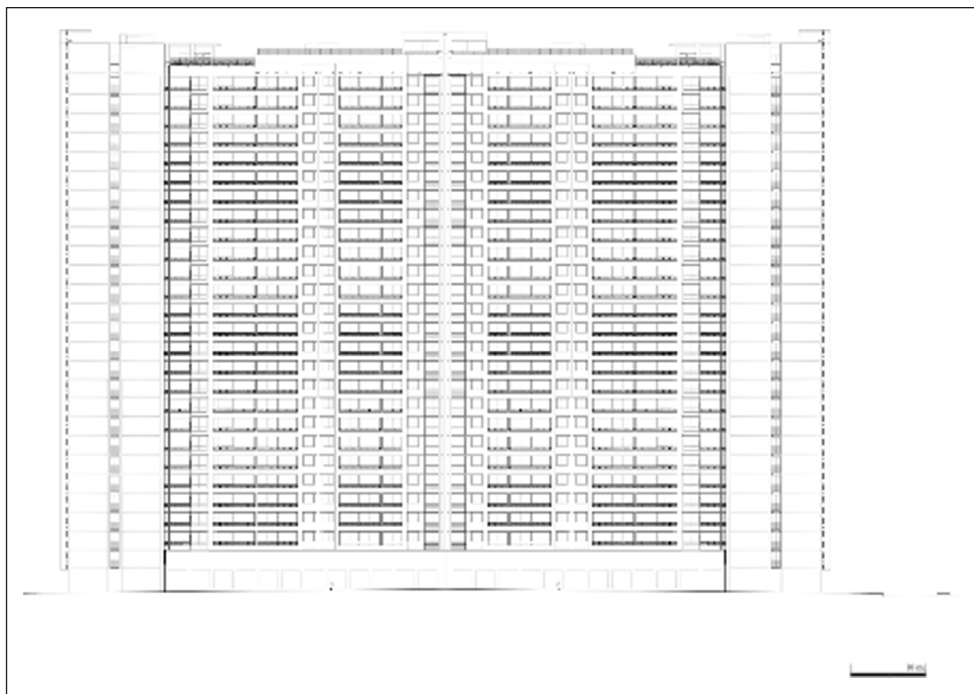


Figure 5. Elevations of Two Towers, Part of the Same Block. Projects Named Alameda Plaza and Santa Petronila Plaza

Source. Environmental Assessment Service.

social dynamics. The uniformity of levels and centralised circulations symbolise spatial rationalisation, a strategy catering to the economic imperatives of the real estate market. The absence of significant transitions between common and residential spaces reinforces a sense of segregation and depersonalisation – hallmarks of vertical ghettos – highlighting how design reproduces dynamics of exclusion and social alienation within its spatial configuration.

The Meaning of the Vertical Ghetto

The semiotic analysis of floor plans, elevations and sections from Santiago's vertical ghettos confirms that design logics of modular repetition and compressed communal spaces resonate with broader critiques of financialised urban development. Vergara-Perucich (2021) argues that housing commodification under neoliberal regimes transforms dwellings into fungible assets, a process vividly illustrated by the interchangeable unit layouts observed in Figures 4 to 6. These standardised plans, prioritising sellable area over resident well-being, echo Urbina Julio's (2024) findings that densification subsidies incentivise developers to maximise FARs at the expense of social infrastructure. Such configurations align with Cattaneo Pineda's (2011) concept of speculative territorialisation, wherein regulatory flexibility is exploited to accelerate profit-driven construction, leaving minimal space for collective amenities.

The conspicuous absence of varied communal nodes within the analysed sections highlights how these towers may inhibit social interaction, supporting Harris et al.'s (2023) critique that neoliberal design often erodes community cohesion. Whereas Newman's (1972) defensible space theory would advocate clear territorial thresholds to foster stewardship, the homogenised cores documented here offer neither semi-private thresholds nor welcoming gathering spaces. This

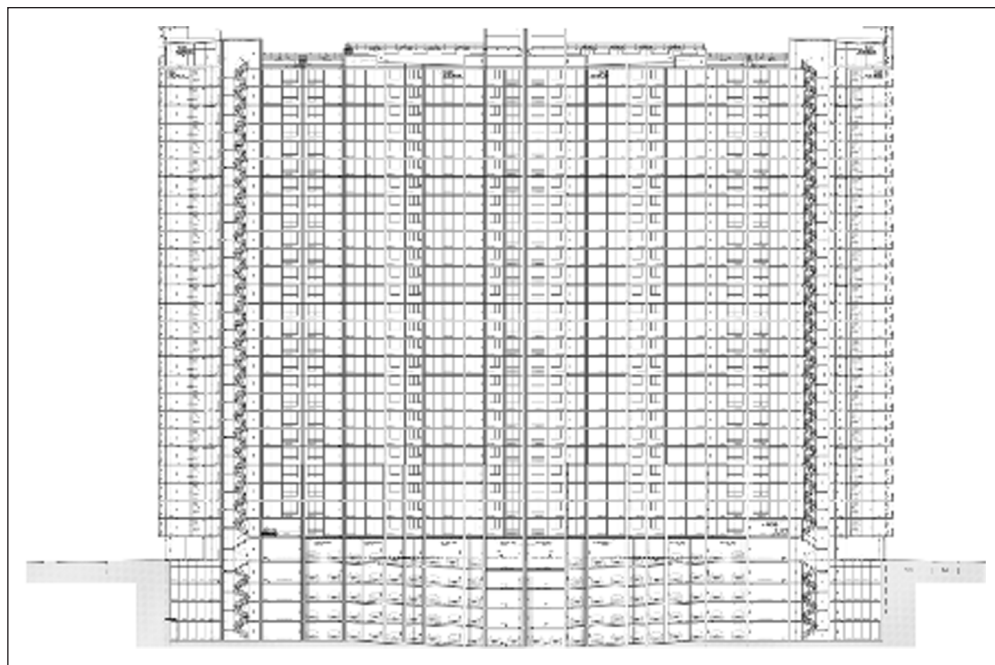


Figure 6. Sections of Two Towers, Part of the Same Block. Projects Named Alameda Plaza and Santa Petronila Plaza

Source. Environmental Assessment Service.

spatial logic can be read as a form of ‘silent enclosure’ (Pinkster et al., 2020), embedding stigmatising narratives of isolation into the built environment. Residents become anonymous occupants of a transactional architecture, reflecting Lefebvre’s (1991; Coleman, 2015) thesis that rationalised space under capitalism effaces social relations.

Elevations marked by monotonous façades reinforce a visual mythology of efficiency, a phenomenon Schmid (2022) describes as architectural encoding of power structures. The symmetrical grid of balconies and windows conveys an ideology of uniformity, mirroring Wacquant’s (1997) observation that poverty is spatially inscribed through built form. Rather than offering legible place-markers or distinctive identities, these façades erase difference, underscoring Gilfoyle’s (2020) assertion that contemporary ghettos materialise racial-capitalist exclusions. In this light, the vertical ghetto emerges as a semiotic text that naturalises speculative logics.

Vertical ghettos in Estación Central are not neutral responses to land scarcity but deliberate spatial embodiments of neoliberal rationality. Through denotative patterns – repetitive modules, centralised cores and minimal shared areas – and their connotative myths of efficiency and anonymity, these towers crystallise the tensions between capital imperatives and communal well-being documented across the literature. Semiotic analysis thus offers a possible definition of the vertical ghetto typology.

The semiotic reading of Santiago’s vertical ghettos identifies a series of formal choices – modular repetition, compressed FARs and the near absence of shared amenities – that align closely with market-driven imperatives in Chilean urbanism. By focusing on plans, sections and elevations, this study demonstrates that repeated unit typologies and minimised communal cores can be understood as strategies to maximise sellable area rather than to cultivate social interaction. Such configurations do not, by themselves, prove processes of dispossession or measured

increases in inequality, but they do signal a design logic in which economic efficiency is prioritised over collective well-being.

Although the towers' standardised façades and circulation schemas cannot alone confirm exclusionary intent, they do suggest an architectural vocabulary of anonymity and control. The lack of diverse communal thresholds tends to limit spontaneous encounters, pointing to a spatial form that may discourage the emergence of neighbourhood solidarities. These features resonate with broader critiques of financialised urban development – where densification often proceeds without integrated social infrastructure (Urbina Julio, 2024; Vergara-Perucich, 2021; Vergara-Perucich & Boano, 2024)—yet our findings remain tethered to the semiotic evidence at hand rather than to untested claims about lived inequality.

Where the research can most confidently speak is to the coherence of these patterns as an ideological 'script' embedded within the drawings themselves. The repetition of identical plan modules and the erasure of distinguishing details convey a message of interchangeability that mirrors speculative logics in real-estate markets. This does not definitively show that residents experience dispossession, but it does foreground the symbolic dimensions of such developments: housing rendered as a fungible commodity.

A subsequent research phase – incorporating interviews, focus groups and policy discourse analysis – will be necessary to trace how these formal signs translate into everyday experiences and perceptions. Such mixed-methods work will allow us to test whether the semiotic patterns identified here also manifest as concrete effects on social cohesion, resident agency and claims to the city.

Conclusion

The denotative and connotative readings conducted in this study demonstrate that the architectural form of Santiago's vertical ghettos – manifested through repetitive floor plan modules, uniform façades and the near absence of shared amenities – articulates a spatial logic aligned with market-driven imperatives. Rather than simply optimising land use, these configurations signal a preference for economic efficiency that can depersonalise residents and curtail opportunities for social interaction, echoing broader patterns of speculative real estate production in Chile (Vergara-Perucich, 2021).

By confining the analysis to planimetric and elevation data, this research foregrounds the semiotic potency of built form but inevitably omits the experiential dimension of everyday life in these towers. Without direct engagement with inhabitants or policy-makers, the study cannot conclusively determine how the identified signifiers translate into lived perceptions of exclusion or agency. Nor does it capture the normative forces and political negotiations that enabled these developments.

Future work should therefore integrate qualitative methods – interviews, focus groups and participatory mapping – to validate and enrich the semiotic interpretations presented here. Such a mixed-methods approach will clarify the extent to which architectural signs of anonymity and control correspond with residents' narratives and urban governance practices. Ultimately, by combining rigorous semiotic analysis with grounded sociological inquiry, scholars and practitioners can better diagnose – and challenge – the exclusionary spatial dynamics that vertical ghettos inscribe into the contemporary city.

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